

Postpartum - Leg Pain - Female (Adult)

Algorithm 1433 | Adult (18 years and older) | Gender at birth: Female

Definition

- Postpartum leg pain assessment, generalized from NHS.UK's C-section recovery blood-clot warning sign to all postpartum deliveries, given the same elevated clot risk applies.
- Adult patient.
- Female.

Initial assessment

1. [DURATION] How many days/weeks since delivery?
2. [LOCATION] Which leg, and where exactly?
3. [YES_NO] Any shortness of breath or chest pain?
4. [YES_NO] If the patient is under 18, can they speak privately now, and do they say they feel safe with the accompanying adult?

Triage and redirect questions

1. Redirect → Neurologic Deficit

Is new weakness, numbness, facial change, speech difficulty, or loss of coordination the primary concern?

A continuing focal neurologic deficit belongs in the Neurologic Deficit pathway.

1. Disposition level 100

Is there swelling or pain in one leg (especially the calf), along with shortness of breath or chest pain?

NHS.UK C-section recovery guidance lists leg swelling/pain as a blood clot warning sign - the postpartum period carries an elevated clotting risk regardless of delivery method, and breathing/chest symptoms suggest the clot may have traveled to the lungs.

1. Disposition level 70

Is there leg pain or swelling without breathing or chest symptoms?

Any new leg swelling or pain in the postpartum period should be checked promptly given the elevated blood clot risk.

Advice

Emergency postpartum blood clot precautions

- Call Qatar emergency services on 999 now. Keep the patient at rest and do not let them drive. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency care.
- Call Back If: worsening breathing difficulty; chest pain develops.

Urgent postpartum leg pain review

- Arrange prompt in-person assessment to rule out a blood clot; the exact non-emergency Qatar destination remains GOVERNANCE_REQUIRED. Call 999 if chest pain, breathing difficulty, fainting, or coughing blood develops.
- Call Back If: breathing difficulty or chest pain develops; swelling worsens.

First aid

- Call Qatar emergency services on 999 now. Keep the patient at rest and do not let them drive. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency care.

References

- NHS.UK, "Caesarean section - Recovery" (blood clot warning sign), <https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/caesarean-section/recovery/> (page last reviewed 04 January 2023) - generalized to all postpartum deliveries

Provenance

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